



Performance review phrases for needs improvement: 24 fair ways to say it (2026)

Last checked 5 October 2026. Fill in the [BRACKETS] with your own facts.

Quality of work

Some work needed correcting before it could be used: for example, [WHAT WAS CORRECTED AND HOW OFTEN].

Errors reached [THE CUSTOMER OR THE NEXT TEAM] on [NUMBER] occasions: for example, [THE CASE].

Reliability

Missed [NUMBER] deadlines in [PERIOD]: for example, [TASK AND DATE].

Problems with deadlines were raised late, so there was little time to help: for example, [THE CASE].

Communication

Messages are often long or unclear, so readers need to ask follow-up questions: for example, [THE MESSAGE].

Important information did not reach [WHO]: for example, [WHAT AND WHEN].

Teamwork

Tends to work alone, and the team has missed their input: for example, [PROJECT].

Has not yet shared information that colleagues needed: for example, [WHAT AND WHEN].

Initiative

Waits to be told what to do next: for example, [THE OCCASION].

Raises problems but does not yet suggest a way forward: for example, [THE PROBLEM].

Problem solving

Fixes the symptom but the same problem returns: for example, [THE PROBLEM].

Asks for help only after a long time on a problem: for example, [THE ISSUE AND HOW LONG].

Saying what you expect

Expectation

What I need to see by [DATE] is [SPECIFIC RESULT], for example [WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE].

Expectation

The standard for this task is [STANDARD]. In [PERIOD] it was met [NUMBER] times out of [NUMBER].

Expectation

I would like [BEHAVIOUR OR RESULT] by [DATE]. We will look at it together on [DATE].

Expectation

To meet this expectation, the first step is [SMALL STEP], by [DATE].

Offering support

Support

I can help by [WHAT YOU WILL DO, FOR EXAMPLE PAIRING YOU WITH A COLLEAGUE OR MEETING WEEKLY].

Support

Is there anything that is getting in the way of [TASK] that I can change? For example, [TOOLS, TIME OR TRAINING].

Support

Training that could help is [COURSE OR PERSON]. Let us agree when you can take it.

Support

I will check in on [DAY] each week for [PERIOD], and we can adjust the plan if needed.

Following up and when it is formal

Follow-up

Since [DATE] I have seen [WHAT HAS IMPROVED]. The part that still needs work is [WHAT].

Follow-up

We agreed on [TARGET] by [DATE]. Where we are now: [FACTS].

Formal

Because this has continued after our talks on [DATES], I will speak to HR about the next steps. I will tell you what that means before anything is decided.

Formal

You can bring [A COLLEAGUE OR REPRESENTATIVE, IF YOUR POLICY ALLOWS] to the next meeting. HR can explain the process and your options.

<https://proskillpacks.github.io/managers/performance-review-phrases-needs-improvement/>

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